

news feed

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hypothesis

CD Mount Rainer ReWrite format

■ What is it?

A packet writing technology that will allow optical disks to be written to and read from with the ease of floppy disks.

■ What does it do?

This standard allows CD-MRW disks to be formatted even while data is being written on the disk, thus saving time. The media can be ejected at any time during the format process—the drive simply picks up where it left off after the media is reinserted.

Fault management will be integrated into the drive hardware itself, instead of through the software as with existing standards such as UDF 1.50. These disks are proposed to have a 2 K addressing system (as opposed to the 64 K addressing system of floppy disks), resulting in a more efficient use of space.

■ What does it imply?

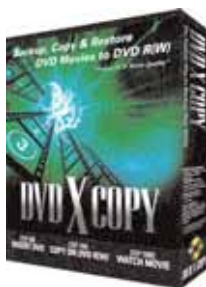
The CD Mount Rainer ReWrite format will facilitate easy reading and writing to optical media using packet writing technologies. Since it will be a standards-based technology, there will be universal compatibility between media and drives. With greater data capacity and reliability, this technology spells the death of the already obsolete floppy disk.

Perfect DVD copies

An American firm called 321 Studios has released a software program that can create mirror images of an entire DVD on a blank DVD. Called DVDCopy, this program can duplicate the menus, special features and enhanced audio.

Hollywood's lobby group, the Motion Picture Association of America (MPAA) has stated that such products violate the Digital Millennium Copyright Act (DMCA), which outlaws tools to circumvent copy-control technology, including the

Contents Scramble System (CSS) used on DVD media. Facing possible criminal prosecution, 321 Studios responded by saying that consumers have a legitimate right to make backup copies of DVDs they own.



To appease Hollywood, DVDCopy intends to introduce a unique digital watermark to enable tracing the DVD source, a disclaimer that the backup is for personal use only and, most importantly, electronic controls embedded into the DVD that prevent the copied DVD from being duplicated further.

E-mail invites burglars

After spam and popup advertisements, the Internet now aids a new malignance. Your e-mail could invite burglars to come and clean your home while you are out of town. Crooks are now buying up huge e-mail lists



Illustrations: Farzana Cooper

over the Internet and sending mass mail in the hope of getting autoreply messages that scream out 'We are not at home'. Smart thieves in the UK are using information within 'Out of Office' autoreply e-mail and are cross ref-

erencing this information against publicly available databases such as 192.com and bt.com that contain names, addresses and telephone numbers. This makes leaving autoreplying messages equivalent to putting up a note on your front door, informing all and sundry about your absence.

The solution is clear—keep your messages bland, redirect enquiries to others or to alternate addresses and do not put personal contact information in your e-mail.

Windows Refund Day

If you want a refund for any Microsoft operating system, your day has arrived. Come January 23, 2003 you can start litigation to get back your money from Microsoft, or from the manufacturer who sold you the OS with your computer.

So, who qualifies for a refund? If you bought a computer that came bundled with a Microsoft OS or if despite having an existing licence, you were forced to obtain another licence for a replacement computer, you can get your money back. But before you head off to a local courthouse, take a look at the licence agreement. You stand to get a replacement only if you can present the proof of ownership and all copies of the software, unopened! The idea is to hold computer manufacturers accountable for refusing to provide a refund for unused copies of any Microsoft OS. Needless to say, the movement has been spearheaded by Linux enthusiasts. Incidentally, this movement comes around in the same week as the Linux-World Expo at New York.

snapshot

Total cost of ownership of Linux could be as much as 22% higher than Windows 2000

Source: IDC